# Hailstorm Player Manual

Nov 11, 2026 · @James Parrott

Hailstorm is a three-stage vertical bullet hell for the LowRes NX fantasy console: fight through enemy waves, then a boss, in each stage, and chain grazes and cancelled bullets into a score multiplier.

## Getting started

1. Install LowRes NX on your computer, phone or tablet, or use the web version.
2. Open `Hailstorm.nx` in it. On a computer, drag the file into the LowRes NX window.
3. Keep `Hailstorm.png` in the same folder as the program. LowRes NX shows it as the program's icon.
4. On the title screen, pick a difficulty with left and right, then press A.

Your high scores are saved automatically when you quit. Leave the title screen alone for 20 seconds to watch a demo of one of the bosses; press any button to return.

## Controls

| Input | Action |
|---|---|
| D-pad | Move |
| A (hold) | Fire |
| B (hold) | Focus: move slowly and show your hitbox |
| B, B (double-tap) | Bomb |
| Pause | Pause the game |

Only a single pixel at the centre of your ship can be hit. Focus shows a ring around it so you can thread through tight gaps. Touching an enemy ship is fatal, just like a bullet.

## Scoring

Everything you score during play is multiplied by your chain, shown as X1 to X8 next to your score.

| Source | Points (before the multiplier) | Raises the chain |
|---|---|---|
| Hitting a boss | 10 per hit | No |
| Grazing (a bullet brushes your ship but misses the hitbox) | 3 per frame | Yes |
| Score gem | 30 per bullet it came from | Yes |
| Dart / orb / gunship destroyed | 200 / 400 / 1,000 | Yes |

**Bombs.** Double-tap B to bomb. Every bullet on screen turns into a gold gem that flies to you, enemies in the wave take heavy damage, the boss takes a hit, and you are briefly invincible. A bomb halves your chain. You start with 3 bombs and are topped back up to 3 each time you lose a life.

**Free gems.** Bullets also turn into gems, for free, when a boss changes phase and when it dies.

**Losing a life** resets the chain to X1.

Flat bonuses are not multiplied: 1,000 or 5,000 per boss phase, 2,000 per battleship turret, and a stage clear bonus of 5,000 per ship left (including the one you are flying) plus 10,000 per stage number.

## The stages

Each stage opens with waves of darts, orb drones and gunships. When the last one is gone a siren sounds and the boss arrives.

| Stage | Boss | Phase 1 | Phase 2 | Phase 3 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. The Storm Begins | Eye-core gunship | Twin spirals of bullet clusters, plus aimed shots | Rings of large bullets and drifting 8-bullet rings | Aimed fans, while a wall of bullets scrolls down the screen. Find the gap or weave through the lattice. |

| Stage | Boss | Phase 1 | Phase 2 | Phase 3 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2. Battleship Inbound | Battleship | Four turrets fire aimed spreads. The armoured centre blocks your shots, so destroy the turrets. | Once all turrets are down the core opens, the ship shimmers with heat and fires twin spirals and rings. Shoot the core. | None |
| 3. Entering the Grid | Wing ship with two orbiting pods | Pods fire aimed spreads while the ship rains bullets | A three-arm spiral of clusters, plus rings from the pods | The grid turns red and speeds up. A counter-spinning flower with fast aimed fans. |

The boss's health bar runs along the top of the screen under the score. Stage 3 is fought above a scrolling perspective floor that tilts as you move.

## Difficulty and high scores

| Difficulty | Enemy bullet speed |
|---|---|
| Easy | 80% |
| Normal | 100% |
| Hard | 120% |

Each difficulty keeps its own top 5 table. The title screen alternates between the controls and the table for the selected difficulty, and the HI score at the top follows your choice.

If your score makes the top 5, you enter three letters after the results: up and down change the letter, A confirms it, B goes back one letter.

# Unlockables and secrets

Unlocks are saved permanently. Once one is unlocked, choose it on the title screen: left and right for difficulty, up and down for mode.

| Unlock | How to earn it | What you get |
|---|---|---|
| Stage select | Clear the game on any difficulty | Start at stage 2 or stage 3 |
| HELL difficulty | Clear the game on Hard | Bullets at 140% speed, with its own top 5 table |
| Gold ship | Reach an X8 chain | Your ship and life icons turn gold |
| Boss rush | Clear the game without losing a life | All three bosses back to back, with no waves |

Three more secrets aren't announced in the game:

- **The true final boss.** Clear stage 3 without losing a life, and without cheats, and the game doesn't end. The Eye of the Storm appears: a 64×64 eye guarded by four orbiting shield pods that block your shots. Its three phases are falling hail with rings, a shimmering vortex where the pods spray along their orbit, and a storm-eye flower with lightning. Beat it for a 100,000 bonus, the true ending, and a new subtitle on the title screen.
- **Gold gunship.** Destroy every enemy in a stage's waves without letting a single one escape off screen. A gold gunship then loops across the top before the boss arrives. Kill it before it bolts for 5,000 points (times your chain) and a bomb.
- **Graze extend.** Graze 1,500 times in one run to earn an extra life, once per game.

## Cheat codes (spoilers)

Enter these on the title screen. The final A starts the game. Cheated runs don't record high scores or earn unlocks, and the results screen says so.

| Code | Effect |
|---|---|
| Up Up Down Down Left Right Left Right B A | Start with 9 lives |

| Code | Effect |
|---|---|
| B B B B B A | Invincible |
| Left Left Right Right B B A | Unlock everything (stays on the title, doesn't mark you as cheating) |

## Tips

- Hold B while weaving through dense patterns. Your hitbox is a single pixel.
- Grazing is free points and chain. Skim the edge of slow streams on purpose.
- Don't hoard bombs: you get them back when you lose a life. Bomb a pattern you can't read, and accept the halved chain.
- In stage 1's final phase the bullet wall always has a gap that drifts. Watch for it at the top of the screen before it reaches you.
- On the battleship, the centre armour soaks up shots. Take the turrets out first, starting with the outer two.
- Orb drones fire a ring about every 1.5 seconds. Kill them early to keep the screen clear for the gunships.

## Under the hood

Hailstorm is written in LowRes NX BASIC and uses the console's limits of 64 sprites, two background layers and a fixed CPU budget per frame. It works around them like this:

- **Bullet clusters.** One sprite can carry 3, 4 or 8 bullets, so 52 bullet sprites put over 200 bullets on screen.
- **One-call collision.** A single `SPRITE HIT` checks your hitbox against every bullet, pixel-exact. A second checks grazing.
- **Raster split.** Code that runs before each screen line keeps the HUD fixed while the starfield on the same layer scrolls endlessly.
- **Stage 1's bullet wall** is drawn into a background layer and scrolled by the hardware, so hundreds of bullets cost almost no CPU.
- **Stage 2's battleship** is 96×40 pixels of background tiles moved by scrolling, with sprite turrets on top. Its heat shimmer shifts each line sideways.

- **Stage 3's floor** is a static perspective grid. Each line is scrolled for steering and recoloured to make depth bands rush toward you.
- **Shared art.** Mirrored tiles, flipped sprites, and enemies reusing boss and player art keep everything within 256 characters. The true final boss is drawn in font slots for punctuation the game never prints, so new in-game text must avoid " # $ % & ' ( ) * + , - . ; = ? @ [ \ ] ^ _ characters.

The source code is included in the `.nx` file. Open it in the LowRes NX editor to read it or change it. Set `GODDBG=1` near the top to play invincible, or `FIRSTSTG=2` or `3` to start at a later stage.